

Orthopaedics Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS - ORTHOPAEDICS SERVICE LINE HANDBOOK

Version 2.1

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1.0 PURPOSE AND SCOPE

1.1 This handbook defines the operational parameters for the Orthopaedics service line at Meridian Health Partners.

1.2 It establishes clear guidelines for patient acceptance, appointment protocols, patient preparation, insurance plan coverage, and referral management.

1.3 This document applies to all Orthopaedics clinical and administrative staff across all 14 Meridian Health Partners sites.

2.0 CONDITIONS ACCEPTED AND NOT ACCEPTED

2.1 Conditions Accepted for Outpatient Management:

2.1.1 Osteoarthritis (knee, hip, shoulder, ankle, hand/wrist)

2.1.2 Rotator Cuff Injuries (tendinopathy, partial tears)

2.1.3 Meniscal Tears (degenerative, stable traumatic)

2.1.4 Ligamentous Sprains (ACL, MCL, LCL, ankle sprains – chronic or stable acute)

2.1.5 Carpal Tunnel Syndrome

2.1.6 Trigger Finger, De Quervain's Tenosynovitis

2.1.7 Plantar Fasciitis, Achilles Tendinopathy

2.1.8 Stable, Closed Fractures (e.g., distal radius, metacarpal, metatarsal, ankle without significant displacement, non-operative vertebral compression fractures). Requires initial imaging review to confirm stability.

2.1.9 Ganglion Cysts, Lipomas (requiring excision)

2.1.10 Bursitis, Tendinitis (chronic, refractory to conservative care)

2.2 Conditions Explicitly NOT Accepted for Outpatient Management:

2.2.1 Acute Trauma Requiring Emergency Intervention: Patients presenting with open fractures, neurovascular compromise, GCS < 13, or significant polytrauma must be immediately directed to Aurelia General Hospital Emergency Department.

2.2.2 Complex Spinal Deformities: Scoliosis > 40 degrees Cobb angle, kyphosis > 60 degrees, or spinal instability requiring fusion. Referrals for these conditions must be directed to the Spine Institute of Aurelia.

2.2.3 Pediatric Congenital Deformities: Conditions such as clubfoot, congenital hip dysplasia, or limb length discrepancies in patients under 12 years of age. Referrals must be directed to Aurelia Children's Hospital Orthopaedics.

2.2.4 Metastatic Bone Disease: Patients with known or suspected metastatic lesions to bone requiring oncologic management. Referrals must be directed to Meridian Oncology Services for initial assessment.

2.2.5 Diabetic Foot Ulcers with Osteomyelitis: Cases requiring complex wound care or inpatient antibiotic management. Referrals must be directed to Aurelia Advanced Wound Care Center.

3.0 TYPICAL APPOINTMENT DURATION

3.1 New Patient Consultation: 45 minutes

3.2 Established Patient Follow-up: 20 minutes

3.3 Post-Operative Visit (initial): 30 minutes

3.4 Injection Visit (single joint): 15 minutes

3.5 Minor Procedure (e.g., simple aspiration, splinting): 30 minutes

4.0 PATIENT PREPARATION INSTRUCTIONS

4.1 All patients are issued preparation instructions at the time of scheduling. These include:

4.1.1 Arrival Time: Patients must arrive 15 minutes prior to their scheduled appointment to complete necessary paperwork and verify insurance.

4.1.2 Imaging: Patients must bring any relevant imaging studies (X-rays, MRI, CT scans) performed outside Meridian Health Partners on CD or access codes.

4.1.3 Clothing: Patients should wear loose, comfortable clothing that allows for easy access to the area of concern for examination. For lower extremity issues, shorts are recommended.

4.1.4 Medication List: Patients must bring an updated list of all current medications, including dosages and frequency.

4.1.5 Transportation: For appointments involving procedures requiring local anesthetic or potential pain medication administration, patients are advised to arrange for a driver if they anticipate impaired driving ability. This explicitly includes all intra-articular steroid injections.

5.0 MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS PLAN COVERAGE FOR ORTHOPAEDICS

5.1 Meridian Core Plan:

5.1.1 Covers initial consultations, diagnostic imaging (X-rays), physical therapy referrals.

5.1.2 Covers up to two (2) corticosteroid joint injections per affected joint per 12-month period for chronic osteoarthritis.

5.1.3 Excludes all surgical procedures.

5.2 Meridian Enhanced Plan:

5.2.1 Covers all services under Meridian Core.

5.2.2 Covers minor outpatient surgical procedures including carpal tunnel release, trigger finger release, de Quervain's release, ganglion cyst excision, and simple arthroscopy for meniscal tears where the tear size is confirmed by MRI to be less than 3 cm.

5.2.3 Covers diagnostic MRI and CT scans with prior authorization.

5.3 Meridian Premium Plan:

5.3.1 Covers all services under Meridian Enhanced.

5.3.2 Covers major outpatient surgical procedures including arthroscopic rotator cuff repair, labral repair (shoulder/hip), and partial knee arthroplasty for patients with unilateral compartmental arthritis and a Body Mass Index (BMI) under 35.

5.3.3 Covers advanced regenerative therapies (e.g., PRP injections) with a 50% patient co-pay after prior authorization.

5.4 Meridian Elite Plan:

5.4.1 Covers all services under Meridian Premium.

5.4.2 Covers complex outpatient joint reconstruction procedures, including total shoulder arthroplasty (for eligible patients meeting outpatient criteria), multi-ligament knee reconstruction, and revision arthroscopic procedures.

5.4.3 Covers a maximum of one (1) orthobiologic procedure per affected joint per 24-month period without patient co-pay, following specific clinical criteria.

5.5 All coverage is subject to medical necessity determination and standard Meridian Health Partners prior authorization protocols.

6.0 REFERRAL TURNAROUND COMMITMENT

6.1 Initial Contact: All incoming referrals will receive an initial contact attempt from Orthopaedics administrative staff within 48 business hours of receipt.

6.2 Appointment Scheduling: A first available appointment will be offered to the patient within 5 business days of the initial contact, contingent on patient availability and clinical urgency as triaged by the Orthopaedics medical director, Dr. Lena Petrova.

6.3 Urgent referrals, as determined by the referring physician and triaged by Orthopaedics, will be scheduled within 24 business hours.